

MIMO Techniques in 5/6G (F-js851-3*)

Technical Milestone Report

Kaiyuan Bao (kb784)

Homerton College, University of Cambridge

Supervised by Prof. Albert Guillen i Fabregas and Alexander Hamilton (Nokia)

May 14, 2026

Abstract

This report summarises the current progress of a 5G New Radio (NR) downlink simulation project with a focus on channel state information (CSI) feedback. The downlink transmission framework is first reviewed to establish the technical background. Based on the simulation framework developed using MATLAB, preliminary downlink throughput results are presented and compared against 3GPP reference results. Finally, the report outlines the planned next steps of the project and discusses potential risks and challenges in the future.

1 Introduction

Mobile telecommunications have experienced rapid development over the past two decades. Starting from the deployment of third-generation (3G) systems in the early 2000s, followed by the introduction of fourth-generation long-term evolution (4G LTE) in the early 2010s, each generation has delivered substantial improvements in data rate and user experience. For end users, the most noticeable change has been the transition from limited and slow web browsing to smooth video streaming and real-time online services. These improvements were enabled by key physical-layer innovations, including the use of orthogonal frequency division multiple access (OFDMA) in 4G LTE, replacing the code division multiple access (CDMA) used in earlier systems, as well as the introduction of more advanced multi-antenna techniques [1].

Building upon the capabilities of 4G, the fifth-generation mobile communication system (5G) has been designed to further increase data rates, reduce latency, and support a wide range of services. Three main usage scenarios are defined for 5G: enhanced mobile broadband (eMBB), massive machine-type communications (mMTC), and ultra-reliable and low-latency communications (URLLC) [2]. Together, these scenarios impose diverse requirements on 5G, ranging from extremely high data rates to massive device connectivity, as well as stringent latency and reliability constraints. To meet these requirements, multiple-input multiple-output (MIMO) techniques play a central role. In particular, massive MIMO systems enable significant throughput gains through spatial multiplexing, null forming and beamforming [3].

The realization of these requirements relies on globally agreed technical specifications, which are defined by the Third Generation Partnership Project (3GPP), a global standardisation body established in 1998 for the development of specifications for 3G. Its scope has expanded from third-generation of cellular networks to the standardisation and continuous evolution of 4G, 5G, and technologies beyond. The first release of 5G NR, Release 15, was published by 3GPP in 2019, marking the point at which 5G NR became ready for practical implementation. In the release, core technical specifications for 5G NR

transmitter processes the data through the DL-SCH and maps it to the PDSCH, followed by precoding and CP-OFDM modulation before transmission over the wireless channel. At the receiver, the received signal is synchronised, demodulated, and decoded using demodulation reference signals (DM-RS) for coherent detection.

There are two widely used channel models in 5G NR link-level evaluations, namely the tapped delay line (TDL) model and the clustered delay line (CDL) model. Each model has several variants designed to represent different propagation environments such as urban, suburban, and rural scenarios. The TDL model provides a simplified representation of the multipath channel and is commonly used for baseline evaluations or scenarios where spatial characteristics and multi-antenna effects are not modelled.

In the TDL model, the channel is represented as a superposition of multiple discrete propagation paths (taps), each characterised by a specific delay τ_l and a path gain $h_l(t)$:

$$h(t, \tau) = \sum_{l=0}^{L-1} h_l(t) \delta(\tau - \tau_l). \quad (1)$$

The TDL model does not represent angular or spatial features of the propagation channel. In contrast, the clustered delay line (CDL) model incorporates spatial information and therefore provides a more realistic channel description. Similar to the TDL model, the CDL model defines a set of multipath clusters characterised by relative delays and average powers. In addition, each cluster is associated with angular parameters, including the azimuth and zenith angles of departure and arrival (AoD, AoA, ZoD, and ZoA). Each cluster is further decomposed into multiple sub-rays with random initial phases and Doppler components. By modelling these spatial characteristics, the CDL channel model enables a more accurate representation of the spatial characteristics of MIMO channels, at the cost of increased complexity and higher computational cost [6].

In addition to CSI, 5G NR also employs hybrid automatic repeat request (HARQ) to improve the robustness of the transmission through re-transmissions. After DL-SCH decoding at the receiver, an acknowledge/negative acknowledge (ACK/NACK) signal is fed back to the transmitter, which indicates whether a re-transmission is required. In the case of a decoding failure, the transport block is re-transmitted using a different redundancy version (RV) and combined at the receiver, thus increasing the probability of successful decoding [2] [7].

3 Simulation Framework

Table 1 below summarises the baseline system and channel configuration adopted in this study, which is aligned with the assumptions commonly used in 3GPP evaluation studies, including TR 38.753 [8]. Low- and high-mobility scenarios are considered. The low-mobility case assumes a maximum Doppler shift of 10 Hz, corresponding to a UE speed of 3 km/h, a common setting for 3GPP testing. For high-mobility cases, a speed of 120 km/h is used, corresponding to a maximum Doppler shift of approximately 390 Hz for a 3.5 GHz carrier frequency.

The CDL-C channel model is selected as it represents a typical non-line-of-sight (NLOS) urban macro environment and is widely used in 3GPP evaluation studies, while modelling spatial characteristics are essential for the study of CSI feedback. A 4×4 MIMO configuration with up to four transmission layers is considered, reflecting a representative

Table 1: System and channel configuration used in the simulation

Parameter	Value
Carrier frequency	FR1, 3.5 GHz
Subcarrier spacing	30 kHz
Channel bandwidth	106 RBs
Antenna configuration	4 Tx, 4 Rx
Maximum number of layers	4
Channel model	CDL-C
Mobility scenarios	Low (10 Hz), High (120 km/h)
Simulation type	Downlink link-level

frequency range 1 (FR1) deployment while maintaining a manageable simulation complexity. This configuration allows multi-layer transmission as well as rank adaptation to be studied within a single-codeword framework, avoiding additional variability introduced by using an additional codeword, and thus enabling a clearer assessment of the effect of the CSI feedback parameters.

This study focuses on investigating the impact of CSI feedback parameters on downlink transmission performance. The baseline CSI configuration follows the settings specified in relevant 3GPP specifications, including TS 38.101-4 [9]. Both the baseline configuration and the investigated parameter ranges are summarised in Table 2. The investigated ranges represent the set of valid discrete configurations specified by 3GPP.

Unless otherwise stated, all simulations use the baseline CSI configuration listed in Table 2. In each experiment, only a subset of the parameters under investigation is varied, while the remaining parameters are kept fixed at their baseline values to ensure a controlled comparison.

Table 2: CSI feedback configuration

Parameter	Baseline setting	Investigated values
CSI report periodicity	10 slots	2–40 slots
CQI reporting mode	Wideband	Wideband / Subband
PMI reporting mode	Wideband	Wideband / Subband
Subband size	16 RBs	4–32 RBs
RI configuration	Adaptive	Fixed / Adaptive
Codebook type	Type I	Type I
Codebook mode	Mode 1	Mode 1 / Mode 2

4 Model Validation and Simulation Observations

To validate the accuracy of the developed simulation framework, a comparison is conducted against results reported by other firms in R4-2509413 [10] under the baseline parameter settings described in the previous section. The comparison is performed using a fixed four-layer transmission configuration and a fixed MCS setting corresponding to MCS 13 (16-QAM modulation with a target code rate of 490/1024).

As shown in Figure 2, the proposed simulation exhibits a similar throughput trend to the firm-standard baseline. The SNR deviation at the 30% and 70% throughput points remains within a worst-case margin of 4.1 dB and 2.2 dB, respectively, indicating good agreement between the results.

Minor discrepancies are observed, which can be attributed to differences in implementation assumptions and modelling details. Even when following the same 3GPP specifica-

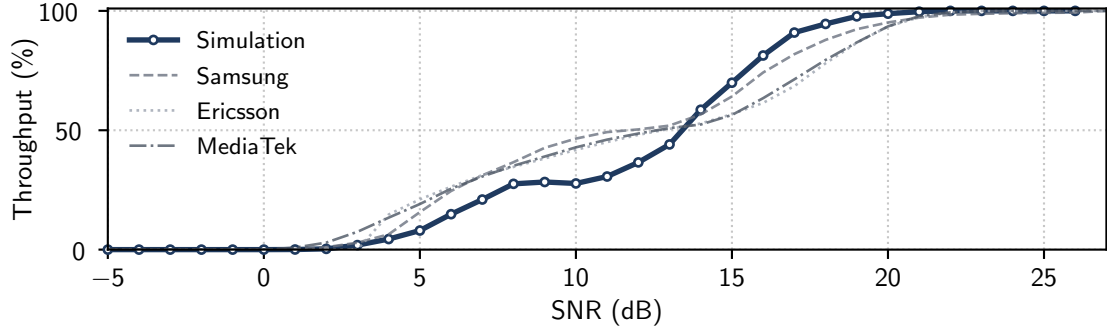


Figure 2: Throughput comparison between the simulation and the firm-standard baseline

tions, results reported by different companies are not expected to be numerically identical. Variations may arise from differences in HARQ process handling, receiver algorithms, and other implementation-specific design choices. The observed deviations between the proposed simulation and the firm-reported results are consistent with the level of variation typically seen across independent 3GPP-aligned evaluations.

Before investigating the CSI feedback parameters, it is useful to examine the impact of HARQ on the throughput and BLER. Figure 3 compares the throughput and BLER results with HARQ enabled and disabled.

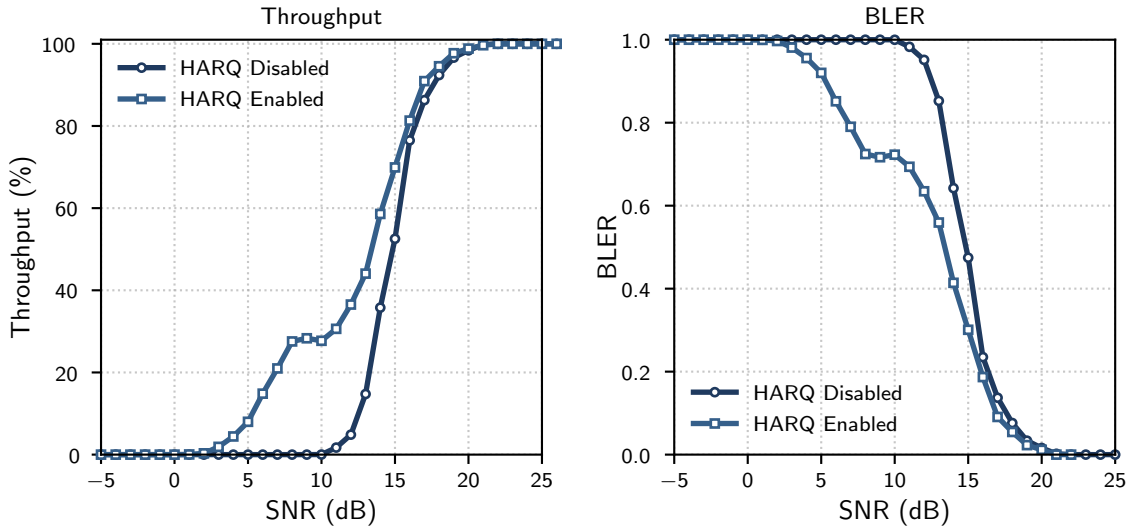


Figure 3: Throughput and BLER performance comparison with HARQ enabled and disabled

With HARQ enabled, a significant reduction in BLER and improvement in the throughput are observed, particularly in the low- to medium-SNR region below 15 dB. When the SNR is beyond 20 dB, whether HARQ is on or off has no impact on the overall performance. All transmissions are successful in a single attempt, and thus no re-transmission is required.

While HARQ provides robustness against decoding errors, its retransmission mechanism can partially mask the direct impact of CSI feedback on link performance. Thus, in the subsequent analysis, HARQ is selectively disabled to better assess the effect of CSI feedback parameters on downlink transmission.

5 Next Steps and Risk Assessment

Based on the constructed simulation framework, the simulations are conducted using the configuration settings described in Section 3 to investigate how different CSI feedback configurations affect downlink transmission performance. More specifically, the study examines how the downlink system behaviour varies with changes in CSI reporting parameters and explores the possibility of identifying an effective configuration under representative scenarios. This analysis considers the trade-off between the performance gains achieved through more accurate CSI feedback and the associated overhead and cost of CSI reporting.

Since this project is entirely simulation-based, no physical laboratory experiments are involved, and therefore no safety-related or hardware-related risks are present. However, few practical risks remain that may impact the depth of the results. The most significant risk is the limited time available for the project relative to the computational cost of the simulations. The simulations are computationally intensive and require substantial run-time on personal computers, as the overall simulation time scales approximately linearly with the number of 10 ms radio frames simulated. While preliminary testing and proof-of-concept experiments can be performed using fewer than 50 frames, obtaining statistically reliable and representative performance results typically requires at least 200 frames.

To mitigate this risk, multiple approaches have been applied and evaluated. These include the use of the MATLAB Parallel Computing Toolbox to fully utilise multi-core CPU resources, as well as running simulations on the CUED central computing system (ts-access) in addition to the personal computer. Furthermore, to reduce the overall computational burden, selected experiments may focus on a limited number of representative SNR operating points rather than sweeping the full SNR range with uniform resolution. This allows high-fidelity analysis at key operating regions while significantly reducing total simulation time, without compromising the validity of the observed performance trends.

6 References

- [1] A. Manikas, “Principles of 3G (CDMA), 4G (OFDMA) and 5G,” Imperial College London EE303 Communication Systems.
- [2] E. Dahlman, S. Parkvall, and J. Sköld, *5G NR: The Next Generation Wireless Access Technology*, 2nd ed. Academic Press, 2020.
- [3] Ericsson AB, “Massive MIMO.” [Online]. Available: <https://www.ericsson.com/en/ran/massive-mimo>
- [4] 3GPP, “3rd Generation Partnership Project (3GPP).” [Online]. Available: <https://www.3gpp.org/about-us/introducing-3gpp>
- [5] MathWorks, “NR PDSCH Throughput Using Channel State Information Feedback,” 5G Toolbox Documentation. [Online]. Available: <https://www.mathworks.com/help/5g/ug/nr-pdsch-throughput-using-csi-feedback.html>
- [6] ETSI TR 138 901, “Study on channel model for frequencies from 0.5 to 100 GHz,” ETSI, Tech. Rep., Nov. 2020.
- [7] MathWorks, “Model 5G NR transport channels with HARQ,” 5G Toolbox Documentation. [Online]. Available: <https://www.mathworks.com/help/5g/gs/model-5g-nr-transport-channels-with-harq.html>
- [8] 3GPP, “Study on spatial channel model for demodulation performance requirements for NR,” 3GPP, Tech. Rep. Release 19, Sep. 2025.
- [9] 3GPP, “User Equipment (UE) radio transmission and reception. Part 4: Performance requirements,” 3rd Generation Partnership Project (3GPP), Tech. Rep. TS 38.101-4, Sep. 2025, Release 19.
- [10] 3GPP, “Results collection table for NR SCM,” 3rd Generation Partnership Project (3GPP), Bengaluru, India, Tech. Rep. R4-2509413, Aug. 2025, RAN4 Meeting #116.